

« We need to stop chasing big names for coaching roles; finding suitable candidates is key »

TAMIM IQBAL

Shayan Acharya

shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

Tamim Iqbal, once one of Bangladesh's most successful captains, faced a challenging period last year after being dropped from the ODI World Cup squad.

Despite the setbacks, the dynamic batter has embraced a new role as a television commentator.

While Tamim is gearing up for a return to the Bangladesh Premier League next year, the question remains: will he also make a comeback to international cricket?

In this interview with *Sportstar*, Tamim shares his future plans, vision for Bangladesh cricket and reflects on his complex relationship with Shakib Al Hasan, who recently announced his retirement from Tests and T20Is.

How has the last one year been for you?

It has been quite a journey, to be honest. I never thought I wouldn't be playing for Bangladesh. At the time, my goal was to play in the Champions Trophy and then make a decision about my career. But then, a lot of unexpected things happened,

and they weren't pleasant either.

You can have bad relationships or differences with people, but when it comes to the national interest, everyone should come together. There should be no room for vindictiveness. Unfortunately, that wasn't the case.

I'm a very emotional person, and what happened to me during that period wasn't easy to handle, which led me to step away.

Many people believe my retirement was an emotional outburst, but it wasn't. Three days before the announcement, I spoke to my family about quitting cricket, so there must have been a reason, right?

I've played for Bangladesh for 17 years, but I had never witnessed anything like what I saw during that time. It was this experience that ultimately pushed me to announce my retirement.

How did you handle the phase?

Imagine I am the captain of Bangladesh and successful at that. I was performing well with the bat too, so everything seemed to be

going my way. Then why did I suddenly retire? What really happened?

Was it because I failed in just two or three games? No. Throughout my career, I've faced failures many times. If my place in the team had been in question, that would have been a different situation, and retirement might have made sense. But I was the captain, and statistically, I am probably one of the most successful ODI captains in Bangladesh's history.

On the surface, everything appeared smooth, so why did I step away? There must have been something I didn't enjoy, someone creating a situation that pushed me towards making this decision.

If you could share what exactly happened?

(Smiles) A lot of things happened. More than one person was involved, and they all played their roles very cleverly. However, I can't name them for obvious reasons. To this day, I haven't blamed anyone, and I never will. They know what they did to me, and I know what they did, so let's